

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Tyndale Open Study Notes

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Laziness and Hard Work

God created Adam and Eve and placed them in the garden of Eden to care for it, not just to relax and enjoy it ([Genesis 2:15](#)). Work is not a punishment from when humans first sinned. Instead, God made work to be a good and valuable part of his creation from the beginning.

The book of Proverbs often condemns laziness (being unwilling to work or make an effort when you should). Proverbs compares lazy people to a door that moves back and forth but never goes anywhere ([Proverbs 26:14](#)). It also teaches that lazy people are foolish ([22:13](#)). Their lack of work leads to poverty and death ([6:6-10](#); [10:26](#); [15:19](#); [18:9](#); [19:15](#), [24](#); [20:4](#); [21:25](#); [22:13](#); [24:30-34](#); [26:13-16](#)). In contrast, hardworking people are wise. Their work leads to having enough money and a good life ([10:4-6](#); [12:11](#); [13:4](#); [20:13](#); [31:10-27](#)).

Ultimate meaning and fulfillment do not come from hard work ([Ecclesiastes 2:17-26](#)). We should not forget God's ability to provide ([Psalm 127:2](#)). But, we have no excuse to be lazy. God designed us to use our gifts and abilities to be productive and provide for ourselves and others ([Ephesians 4:28](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:11-12](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:6-13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:12](#); [Proverbs 6:6-11](#); [10:4-6](#), [26](#); [12:11](#), [24](#), [27](#); [13:4](#), [11](#); [14:4](#), [23](#); [15:19](#); [18:9](#); [19:15](#); [21:5](#), [25](#); [24:30-34](#); [26:13-16](#); [28:19](#); [31:10-31](#); [Ecclesiastes 2:18-26](#); [4:5-6](#); [5:12](#); [9:10](#); [11:4-6](#); [Romans 12:11](#); [Ephesians 4:28](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:11-12](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:10-15](#)

Legalism

The law was very important to the Jewish people. Their understanding of religion often focused on following rules and ceremonies. This was natural to them because God had given his law to the Jewish

people. He did this to show he had chosen them as his people. God also gave them the law as a way for them to confirm and keep the covenant agreement he had made with them.

Yet, many Jews added to God's laws, creating rules for almost every situation. They often did this to avoid breaking any of God's laws. As Jesus often pointed out, these extra rules sometimes made it hard to follow God's instructions ([Mark 7:1-15](#)). In addition, many Jews believed that simply following the law would make them favored by God.

The apostle Paul often encountered issues with strict legalism in the early churches. For example, in Colossae, false teachers influenced by Jewish beliefs insisted that Christians follow certain rules to express their faith ([Colossians 2:16-23](#)). Paul criticized this, emphasizing faith in Christ. Christ is the fulfillment of all God's plans and purposes and is the center of true devotion.

This does not mean that rules for behavior are bad in themselves. Some rules, like the prohibition on lying, plainly show an aspect of Christ's character ([Colossians 3:9](#)). Paul also did not mind if individual Christians set rules for themselves that they believe will help them better obey Christ (compare [Romans 14:5](#); [1 Corinthians 8](#)). Yet, they must not force others to follow these self-imposed rules.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 23:13-33](#); [Mark 7:1-15](#); [Galatians 2:14-21](#); [Colossians 2:16-23](#)

Letters to the Seven Churches

In the letters to the seven churches of Asia, the apostle John uses a single literary pattern ([Revelation 2-3](#)). Each letter starts with an address to the "angel of the church" in a specific city. It then mentions an aspect of Jesus' appearance from the vision of "the Son of Man" ([1:12-18](#)).

Jesus says that he knows each church and describes its condition. He gives advice or judgment and

promises a reward for obedience. Each time, Jesus emphasizes the importance of paying full attention to the Holy Spirit's message to the churches.

Interpreters often divide the seven letters into separate messages, symbolizing seven types of people or time periods. Yet, these letters were first from Jesus to specific local churches in Asia. Jesus knows each local gathering of Christians and encourages them to follow him faithfully.

Together, these letters form a unified message for the church at all times and places, knowing its weaknesses. Any local gathering of Christians might resemble one of these churches, and each community has people similar to those Christians. Jesus invites every community of Christians to examine itself using all these messages.

Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 2:1-3:22](#)

Life After Death

Writers in the Old Testament describe the place where dead people are as beneath the earth's surface ([Ezekiel 26:20](#)). Sometimes, the earth swallows them alive ([Numbers 16:31-33](#); [Psalm 55:15](#)). But usually, "the cords of death" take them down "and swallows them" ([Psalm 18:4-5](#); [Numbers 16:30](#); [Job 24:19](#); [Psalm 49:14](#); [Isaiah 5:14](#); [14:11](#)). In the Old Testament, the afterlife is often considered a gloomy, hopeless place of no return ([Job 7:9](#); [Isaiah 38:18](#)).

In the book of Job, the main images of the place of the dead include:

- *Sheol*, which is described as dark and dusty ([Job 11:8](#); [14:13](#); [17:13](#), [16](#); [24:19](#); [26:6](#));
- a pit filled with decay (Hebrew *shakhat*; see [9:31](#); [17:14](#); [33:18](#), [22](#), [24](#), [28](#), [30](#)); and
- the grave (Hebrew *qeber*; see [3:22](#); [5:26](#); [10:19](#); [17:1](#); [21:32](#)).

The Old Testament sometimes suggests rescue from the grave (see [1 Samuel 2:6](#); [Psalms 16:10-11](#); [30:3](#); [49:15](#); [56:13](#); [73:24-26](#); [86:13](#); [139:7-10](#); [Isaiah 26:19](#)). Job hopes *Sheol* might ease his troubles ([Job 3:13-22](#); [14:13-17](#)). He hopes a redeemer might defend him after death ([19:25-](#)

[26](#)). Yet, only the New Testament fully promises redemption from death ([1 Corinthians 15:50-58](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:6](#); [28:11-15](#); [1 Kings 17:20-22](#); [2 Kings 4:32-35](#); [Job 3:13-22](#); [7:9](#); [14:13-17](#); [17:13-16](#); [19:25-27](#); [Psalms 6:5](#); [16:10-11](#); [17:15](#); [49:15](#); [86:13](#); [88:11](#); [139:8](#); [141:7](#); [Proverbs 1:12](#); [15:11](#); [Isaiah 26:19](#); [38:18](#); [Ezekiel 26:20](#); [Matthew 22:31-32](#); [Romans 8:23](#); [1 Corinthians 15:50-58](#); [Philippians 3:21](#)

Little Faith

The Greek term translated as "little faith" and related terms appear five times in the Gospel of Matthew ([Matthew 6:30](#); [8:26](#); [14:31](#); [16:8](#); [17:20](#)). It also appears once in Luke ([Luke 12:28](#); compare [James 1:6-7](#)). This term refers to a specific event, not a permanent failure.

In Matthew, "little faith" occurs when Jesus' disciples lack knowledge or act without faith in a certain situation ([Matthew 16:8-11](#)). If someone always lacks faith, it is called "unbelief" (see [13:58](#)).

Some examples of "little faith" include:

- when the disciples do not understand their worth or God's protection ([6:30](#));
- when the disciples do not trust God's protection during danger ([8:26](#); [14:31](#));
- when the disciples misunderstand Jesus' teaching about yeast ([16:8](#)); and
- when the disciples fail to cast out a demon ([17:20](#)).

These are failures in specific situations, not a total lack of faith.

The term *faith* includes two ideas: *trust* (personal reliance on the Lord) and *belief* (acceptance of truths). Matthew's concern with "little faith" is about a follower of Jesus lacking trust in a specific situation, rather than failing to believe in Jesus as Lord and Savior. Jesus wants his followers to not only believe in him but also to trust, love, and obey him (see [Matthew 7:21-29](#); [22:34-40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 6:30; 7:21-29; 8:26; 13:58; 14:31; 16:8; 17:20; 22:34-40; Luke 12:28; James 1:6-8](#)

Living for Christ

The apostle Paul writes from prison, "For to me, to live is Christ" ([1:21](#)). Why should Christians commit their lives to Jesus Christ?

1. *Christians recognize that they owe everything to Christ.* This includes their salvation. They show their gratitude by committing their lives to his service (see [Romans 12:1](#)).
2. *Christians accept Christ as their master and Lord.* They obey Christ's guidance in their lives. They understand that they belong to the Lord and do not live only for themselves (see [Romans 14:7-9; 2 Corinthians 5:14-15](#)).
3. *Christians now share in Christ's death and resurrection.* They have "died with Christ" and are "alive to God in Christ Jesus" (see [Romans 6:3-14](#); compare [Galatians 2:19-20](#)). They have a new identity in Christ ([Romans 8:14-17; Ephesians 1:11, 14; Philippians 3:20](#)).
4. *Christians understand that all valuable things are in Christ.* Worldly things that once seemed important have lost their appeal. Nothing compares to the immense value of knowing Christ ([Philippians 3:7-11; Ephesians 1:3-3:21; Colossians 1:15-3:4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 6:3-14; 8:14-17; 12:1; 14:7-9; 1 Corinthians 6:19; 2 Corinthians 5:14-15; Galatians 2:19-20; Ephesians 1:11, 14; Philippians 1:21; 3:7-11, 20](#)

Living Water

Israel was a land often experiencing drought. People were very aware of water sources and quality. There were few year-round springs and rivers. So, people relied on a deep hole built underground to collect and store winter rain.

These are called cisterns. They used wells to access underground water.

In Jewish culture, "dead water" meant standing or stored water. "Living water" meant moving water, like rivers, springs, and rainfall. This water was valuable because it was fresh. Since it came directly from God, people used it for ceremonial washings (see [Leviticus 14:5-6, 50-51; 15:13; Numbers 19:17-19](#)).

The difference between "dead" and "living" water explains the confusion of the woman of Samaria when Jesus offered her "living water" ([John 4:12](#)). Samaria does not have a permanent river. If Jacob had to dig a well there, how could Jesus offer better water?

Jesus spoke about living water again in Jerusalem during the autumn Feast of Tabernacles ([John 7:37-39](#)). This feast, held in a dry season, focused on water. In this context, Jesus stepped forward and made a bold claim. Anyone seeking living water should come to him and drink. Jesus is the source of living water. He came directly from God and brought divine renewal through the Holy Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 14:5-6, 50-51; 15:13; Numbers 19:17-19; Song of Solomon 4:15; Jeremiah 2:13; 17:13; John 4:10-14; 7:38-39; James 3:11-12](#)

Love in the Community of Christ

Living in a community is not always easy. The community of Jesus Christ (the church) has often experienced disunity and division throughout its history. Even in its earliest days, the church struggled with unity issues (see [1 Corinthians 1:11-17; Galatians 2:11-16](#)).

To solve conflicts in the Christian community, Christians must show love to one another. Jesus taught this ([Matthew 22:37-40; John 13:34-35](#); see [Leviticus 19:18](#)). The apostle Paul emphasized it ([Romans 13:8-10; 1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#)). It appears throughout the New Testament ([1 Peter 1:22; 1 John 2:7-11; 3:10; 4:7](#)). Loving others in the Christian community is key to Christian values ([Romans 12:9-10; 1 Thessalonians 4:9; 2 Peter 1:5-8](#)).

This kind of love is not just a feeling but a promise to help others, shown through actions. Followers of Christ should treat each other in such a way that

their faith communities are famous for acts of love. The author of Hebrews gives examples of showing love in real ways within Christian communities ([Hebrews 13:1-6](#)).

These include:

1. Being welcoming
2. Helping those persecuted or imprisoned
3. Remaining faithful in marriage
4. Not letting money control their lives

Many people misunderstand love and the character of the church. So, the church must obey the Lord's command to "continue in brotherly love" ([Hebrews 13:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 19:18](#); [Matthew 22:39](#); [John 13:34](#); [Romans 12:10](#); [Romans 13:8](#); [1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:9](#); [Hebrews 6:10](#); [Hebrews 10:24](#); [Hebrews 13:1-6](#); [1 Peter 1:22](#); [2 Peter 1:7](#); [1 John 2:10](#); [1 John 3:10](#); [1 John 4:7](#)

[Leviticus 19:18](#); [Hosea 6:6](#); [Matthew 7:12](#); [9:9-13](#); [12:1-13](#); [22:37-40](#); [23:2-4](#), [13](#), [23](#); [John 13:34-35](#); [Romans 13:8-10](#); [1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#); [Galatians 5:6](#), [22-23](#); [Colossians 3:12-14](#); [1 John 2:7-11](#); [3:11-18](#); [4:7-21](#)

Loving Others

Jesus said that loving your neighbor is the second most important commandment in the Old Testament ([Mark 12:31](#)). The command to love sums up the entire Old Testament law ([Matthew 22:40](#); compare [7:12](#); [9:9-13](#); [12:1-13](#); see [Romans 13:8-10](#)). Jesus criticized the Pharisees for not showing love ([Matthew 9:13](#); [12:7](#); [23:4](#), [13-14](#), [23](#)). Love identifies a true follower of Jesus ([John 13:34-35](#)). It indicates a real experience of God ([1 John 2:9-11](#); [3:11-18](#); [4:7-21](#)).

For the apostle Paul, love is more important than any spiritual gift and is the most important virtue. Love "is the bond of perfect unity" ([Colossians 3:14](#)). Without love, Christian ministry has no value ([1 Corinthians 13:1-3](#)). Paul summarized Christian ethics as "faith expressing itself through love" ([Galatians 5:6](#)).

Love naturally comes from Christian faith. It is the primary fruit of the Holy Spirit ([Galatians 5:22](#)). It is the most important motivation for Christian ministry. As Christians spiritually grow, they will desire to love others as Christ did.

Passages for Further Study